
NAMECOIN
Art claim
Record

QUANTUM

026 / 03 MAY 2014 / DIGITAL ART / COMMON

ART MEETS THE CHAIN.

Kevin McCoy's Quantum is an animated digital artwork: a multicoloured octagonal form pulses against black. In May 2014, McCoy and technologist Anil Dash collaborated at Rhizome's Seven on Seven at New York's New Museum. McCoy registered Quantum on Namecoin. Sotheby's catalogue dates that original registration to 3 May 2014, the date carried by this card.

Their Monegraph experiment connected a digital work with a public claim and a blockchain record. It explored provenance: how a work's history could be followed as it circulated. The image could still be copied. Recording a claim did not verify that the claimant was truthful, guarantee authenticity or automatically establish copyright. Quantum became an early landmark of blockchain art, before Ethereum and the later NFT market.

Here, a fictional chameleon perches above a framed interpretation of Quantum's luminous geometry. Its changing colours echo the animation, bringing a moving digital artwork into the collection's inked anime world. The painted octagon is an illustrative reference, not the original animated file. The creature is neither McCoy nor a historical participant.

The open NAMECOIN book turns a digital record into a readable studio prop. Art claim and Record describe the idea behind the ledger, while paint splashes connect the page to the artist's materials. The studio, frame and paper registry are visual metaphors, not a reconstruction of the 2014 event. ART MEETS THE CHAIN. names the encounter between an artwork and its recorded history.

DETAILS IN THE ART

01 THE COLOUR-CHANGING CURATOR

The fictional chameleon's vivid colours echo Quantum's pulsing animation. Its perch on the frame joins the living character to the digital-art reference; it does not portray a real participant.

02 THE RAINBOW OCTAGON

Concentric colour bands against black recall Quantum's animated octagonal form. This framed illustration is a static interpretation, not the original file or a claim that Quantum was a physical painting.

03 THE NAMECOIN REGISTRY

NAMECOIN, Art claim and Record make the registration idea visible. This paper book is invented. A blockchain record preserves a claim; it cannot by itself prevent copying or guarantee authenticity or copyright.

04 PAINT ON THE PAGE

Paint marks on the registry and the tubes beside it tie record-keeping to artistic work. They are playful studio details, not evidence about the tools, venue or process used in 2014.

SOURCE & ART NOTE

Sources: Sotheby's: Kevin McCoy, Quantum; Rhizome / TRLab: The First NFT; Anil Dash: A Bitcoin for Digital Art. The chameleon, studio, frame and paper registry are fictional metaphors. The card's 3 May 2014 date follows Sotheby's. Dash's 2 May account concerns cars.gif, not a separate dating of Quantum. No uncontested first-NFT claim is made. ART MEETS THE CHAIN. is editorial wording.